

Exercise 1: Inequality Simulation Reflection

For this exercise, you will reflect on your experiences of inequality simulation, which we completed in class on the third day.

First, answer the following questions:

1. Where were you directed to sit at the beginning of the activity? How did you feel about that?

Due to the way that we were arranged (by our birthday, starting with October), I was at the front table. At first I felt really good at being in the front. I figured I could get up and get a card whenever I wanted, and then sit out on other rounds to keep it fair for the other participants. However, I quickly lost hope after round 2.

2. How did you feel when you heard the rules of the game?

Once hearing the rules of the game, I was excited because I felt as though the rules were quite relaxed which allowed for me to use some creativity (block the path with my table, jump over the table, etc.). Although this too changed, once the rule of “no climbing on chairs” came into play, which meant I was at a disadvantage due to my height.

3. What did you do during the simulation, as it was happening? How did you feel?

At first I was using my creative ideas and I was getting to the cards, but the others were faster in actually grabbing in the cards. After getting 0 points for four rounds straight, I felt hopeless and stopped trying (stopped using my best efforts).

4. What did you see other people doing?

During the game, I saw others using similar strategies, like wheeling themselves closer to the cards to start. Similarly, I noticed that after the same people continued to get the cards over and over, my other classmates stopped trying as well.

5. Did you have control over where you moved during the activity? What did you have control over? What did other people control?

I had some control over where I moved in the game. For example, I could've chose to run to the left of my table (into the walkway where everybody else was running), or to run to the right around my table (where I did not have to compete with others). In this same sense, my other classmates had control over where I moved because I was at a disadvantage if I performed the same action (everybody trying to run down the same path at once result in blockage).

6. What were the results of the activity? Why do you think it played out as it did?

The three winners were the same players that consistently got to the cards every round. These three winning individuals were in the front row with me as well. I definitely think this contributed to their success! Additionally, I think these three people were the most advantaged, and due to this reason they started off the first few round successfully. This brought up their morale and reinforced their sense of competitiveness, while my classmates and I slowly lost hope and decreased our efforts.

7. How did you feel at the end of the activity?

At the end of the activity, I was pretty surprised that I had only gotten one point the entire game (despite sitting in arguably the best position possible). This made me feel kind of sad, and like I "wasn't good enough." However, at the same time I thought the game was quite fun and quite fair due to the rules set into place. I wasn't mad with the results, but rather curious with what I potentially did wrong.

Second, in 2 paragraphs, reflect on your experience and how it relates to social stratification. You are free to write about whatever you like, but here are a few jumping-off points you might consider:

The primary aspect of the game that really captured my interest was the emotion. I think everybody who played this game went through an entire range of emotion, throughout the entirety of the game. I also believe the emotion played a critical role in one's game performance. For example, MacKenzie kept getting really high point cards (the "2 points" and "3 points" cards) which fed her sense of competitiveness, and boosted her confidence in her abilities. On the other hand, both Mike and I are great examples of how our emotions inhibited us. I felt like it was no longer worth trying, even being at the very front, because it never resulted in me winning the rounds. Mike was at the very back of the room, which kept him from even

trying at the start, and of course and continued to lose additional hope as the game went on (just like me).

The other really interesting aspect was equity. We actually addressed this at one point in the game. To make things more fair, we decided to factor in “chance” by having a “rock-paper-scissors” match. This indeed did make the game more fair, but it did not remove the issue of stratification. Miles and I still had little to no chance at making it to the final round, despite “chance” now working in our favor. I think this is a common issue that we face in our society, and one that is shared around the globe. No matter how we were arranged in the room (by birthday, by height, etc.), somebody would always be at a disadvantage. That being said, I think there are always things we can do to REDUCE social stratification, but after playing this game I do not believe there is a way to remove it completely. It's not all about your positioning/advantages in society, but emotion plays a critical role as well as I discussed earlier. Even if you can make the rules so that nobody is disadvantaged, some people will still be less likely to succeed due to their sense of “hopelessness.”

Make sure to connect your reflection to real life. How do you think what you wrote about connects to social stratification beyond our classroom?